closing it with the wooden bung to seal the hole. It was laborious work. There was a sheen on his forehead and damp patches under his arms but he didn't complain.

"That's it for today," she said, wiping her forehead with the back of her hand. "Come after lunch tomorrow. The alcohol in the remaining two vats should be ready. And then we can fill the other barrels."

"The Weinführer gave me strict instructions," he said, removing the leather apron.

"Which were?"

"That I should come in the morning and remain all day." His eyes locked on hers.

"It's not necessary, but if that is what you like." She shrugged, trying not to show how uneasy his words made her. "There's always plenty of work at the vineyard. I'll ask Madame LeBlanc tonight about other tasks until the fermentation is complete."

"Tell me where to put this." He held up the apron.

"I'll take it."

"Why don't you give me a key. You can take your time with breakfast. I'll just let myself into the *chai* and sweep—"

"That's very kind of you to offer but that won't be possible. We only have one key to the door."

He handed her the apron. "See you tomorrow morning."

She hung the aprons on the wall. Her stomach twisted as she considered everything Ferney had said. She closed the door and locked it, relieved he was gone until the morning.

Léa entered the kitchen. Virginie was busy peeling the potatoes for dinner.

"How was Monsieur Ferney?" she asked.

"Very curious about the *chai*. Walked all around it, and he asked a lot of questions. Can you think of something for him to do tomorrow morning?"

"There's plenty of wood that needs chopping. The logs are around the back of the property, so he'll be out of our way."

"Good." She sat down. "Any progress on what the rail carts might mean?"

"No. It doesn't make any sense." Virginie wiped her hands on her apron.

Rose and Paulette entered the kitchen, their faces ruddy from the cold.